



she buys to CONQUER

No longer just supporters, today they are bread winners, providing for their families. Marriage marks a significant change in their spending patterns but working women remain a critical segment for companies wanting to cash in on the She Economy.

■ By Aditi Pai and Deepika Khatri

Today's urban Indian woman is shedding inhibitions, opting for a career and is making independent decisions. Almost 16 per cent urban Indian women (17 million women) work outside their homes today and this proportion will increase significantly in the coming years as a result of higher education levels, urbanisation and a gradual change in perception. Women are now a critical consumer segment for marketers to tap, not only for household and conventional women's products but also for technology products like mobile phones, financial products and services. Yet all women do not behave the same—their spending habits differ according to their marital and working status. The She Economy has many shades as the Indian Consumer Trends 2006-07 survey shows. The Knowledge Company, Technopak survey covered 25,000 consumers aged between 12 and 70 from Sec A,B, C households across 50 centres—40 per cent of the respondents were women.

You, me and us

Marriage alters the way a woman allots her expenditure, especially if there are children in the picture. Categories like apparel and accessories seem to take a backseat, while financial products and services are given priority. It's security above ceaseless spending.

Taru Goel Suri, 40, CEO, U-TO Solutions. Mother of a two-year-old son.



SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

Savings: 80 per cent of the monthly income.

Soon after her wedding, Suri shifted to a low-risk investment portfolio, cutting down on stocks and moving towards mutual funds, both equity and debt. "My priorities changed since I wanted a house. And now with a child, we think more about his future while investing," says the 40-year-old CEO of a software development firm. While her husband Sumit Suri, a software professional, continues to dabble in stocks, she prefers jewellery and real estate. "Gold always appreciates, so it is a wise investment. Property is another area I am keen on," she says. The young mother confesses that she isn't a big shopper and most of her monthly expenses (20 per cent of her income) are spent on eating out and shopping for her child.

It's a new girl order. A single working woman spends 27% on apparel and accessories and 19% on books and gifts. The numbers are 23% and 15%, respectively, for married women.